

## AF for driverless bodies

Nikon recently launched a new AF-S 50 mm f1.8 which will autofocus with even the most basic dSLR bodies that don't have drive motors

## Leaked news

Some specifications of Sony's upcoming NEX-7 have leaked, placing the sensor at 24 MP, with an ISO range of 100 to 16000 and 10 fps

## dSLRs Comparison Test

previews. ISO 6400 is grainy, with a lot of loss of detail, and washed out colours.

### PRO DSLRS

#### Canon EOS 1D Mark 4: ₹2,59,995

The camera's built like a tank, has great in-hand feel, tight seams, weather sealing, metal body – the works. However, the rubber grips aren't as cushioned and soft as the Nikon D3x, and neither are the grip's contours as comfortable. The Mark 4 has a crop sensor that is larger than APS-C, called APS-H by Canon. It offers the best of both worlds – better performance in low light than APS-C sensors, and more corner sharpness with lower vignette than full frame ones.

The Mark 4 has a good button layout, despite being different from other Canon cameras. There are no buttons down the left side, they're moved to the left shoulder of the camera. There are 2 status LCDs, both quite small, and the rear one doesn't show a lot of info, unlike the D3x and D3s that allow previewing and changing some settings like WB and ISO. The menus are detailed, and a bit complex, but not as deep as the D3x.

The 1D Mark 4 focuses very fast, and accurately. Its 45 points are good, but the frame coverage is strictly decent, and with so many points, the viewfinder around the centre can look a little busy. Image quality is excellent, as expected. Immediately visible is the far improved specular highlights on the paper clips compared to the 7D and the D7000 that are of course much cheaper cameras. The highlights

are easily at par with the D3x, with the larger sensor on the Nikon only scoring a bit more detail with textures of some fruit.

At ISO 800, the Mark 4 is clean, very clean, with no loss of detail and absolutely no noise. ISO 1600 has a touch of noise, but it's like film grain and looks integral to the output without disturbing it. The details and highlights remain almost unchanged. Some of the texture on the fruit does seem to have become a little less pronounced, but it's still more than what the other crop sensors managed. At ISO 3200, the cloth's fine texture is still clear, and the paper clips still have good highlights although they have lost some detail. Some parts of the cloth that are facing our lights seem to have taken on a slightly greyish tinge from their default black, but really, this is only noticeable in 100 per cent crops. At ISO 6400 there's more noise smearing details, but smaller prints should easily be possible. Surprisingly, the Nikon D7000's output seems a bit close to the Mark 4 – high praise indeed. And through all this, corner sharpness is much better than the D3x, and the Canon 5D Mark 2 (not part of this test).

With its high speed shooting, and amazingly clean and detailed output quality up to ISO 3200, the 1D Mark 4 is really meant for action sports shooters or for pros looking to shoot wildlife. At ₹2,59,995, many people will prefer opting for a full frame and there are some cheaper ones about, but the 1D Mark 4 is the true king of the crops, just not very affordable! Having edged

out the D3x at higher ISOs, it also bagged our Digit Best Performance award.

#### Nikon D3x: ₹5,24,990

We were pretty surprised when Nikon sent us the D3x – a pro studio tool. It's a massive looking camera, with a plush integrated vertical grip, a huge bulge at the top for the large pentaprism viewfinder and a very solid magnesium alloy frame that's weather sealed and covered in certain parts with thick, heavy duty rubber. The D3x is bristling with buttons, dials and knobs, and while the control system is intimidating at first, it grows on you within the first 6 hours of use. It feels better in-hand, than the Canon 1D Mark 4.

The D3x is blessed with dedicated buttons for nearly everything, and in conjunction with



Canon EOS 1D Mark 4

the dials and the 2 status LCDs, accessing vital settings is easy and fast. The menus are very deep though, and loaded with more options than most will use, some require referral to the manual. Most D300 users will feel right at home. The 51-point AF system is fast, has decent frame coverage and focuses extremely accurately.

Owing to its larger sensor, the viewfinder is also a bit brighter than other cameras in this comparison.

The D3x is an older

camera, and video shooting is missed. However, pros will love 24 MP sensor more than makes up in the still image department. The D3x shows excellent resolution and sharpness at base ISOs. In fact, highlighting is so natural it looks like your looking at a real scene and not a captured image. The D3x resolves fine detail and texture very nicely, much more so than the 7D, D7000 and lesser cameras. Though this is only visible when working with 100 per cent crops, and so the D3x is clearly a tool for the discerning professional.

It's not without flaw though, as at ISO 400 a tiny bit of noise creeps in – there's lots of detail, but 100 per cent crops don't look as pristine as they look at ISO 100. ISO 800 is noisier, and while not serious, it is enough that you might not want to use it for images that matter. ISO 1600 and 3200 are not really usable. We've tested the D3s earlier and are happy to announce that it is still the low light champ and is better than all the cameras here, the D3x included. In fact there is an at least 4 ISO stop advantage. In our performance scores, you might be surprised to see the D3x score low, but remember that it doesn't shoot video, and isn't good at higher ISOs. For studio shooting, check the dynamic range and detailing scores – it outscores other cameras quite easily.

It is also good when cropping photos, due to the huge sensor resolution. Pros do a lot of this. It will also allow larger prints if the image is captured at base ISOs (up to ISO 200). Still, blowing upward of ₹5 lakhs on a dSLR that is vulnerable in low light seems daft. If you're looking for something more rounded from Nikon, we recommend the D3s, or waiting for a successor, that could be next year. **4**

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